the visit against both the BJP and the DMK, calling the saffron gestures "political drama", but saying the DMK long ignored the Chola legacy.

The record, of course, reveals a handsome harvesting of history by the latter. As CM in 2010, M. Karunanidhi led the grand millennium gala at Brihadiswara Temple. In 2022, M.K. Stalin made a state event out of Raja Raja Chola's birth anniversary. "Those late to Tamil pride are free to speak," quips a DMK elder. "History knows who lit the lamp first."

Senior journalist Thuglak Ramesh defended the BJP on the charge of being motivated by political gain. "It may appear to be a strategy to counter the perception that the BJP

Takeaways

- **Modi makes a grand visual tour de force out of a two-day political visit to poll-bound TN**
- **DMK says the Hindutva is out of place, as the PM carries *gangajal* to Chola territory**

is alien to Tamil identity. But I have heard the PM genuinely engages with Tamil antiquity. This goes beyond political calculation—it reflects a sincere personal devotion," he says.

Priyan says this is belied by the fact that the BJP strategy in Tamil Nadu mirrors its approach in other states and social demographies, appropriating local or community icons to build cultural bridges. He feels Tamil Nadu's unique polity—grounded in linguistic rights, social justice and federalism—would defy such subsumption. "People appreciate such gestures, but they will still ask tough questions: about flood relief, education funding, archaeological flashpoints, the Governor. Symbolism alone won't suffice." A people who have chosen to be ruled by regional parties since 1967. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

A CASTE ENCORE

Karnataka orders a new caste survey this year, junking the report based on the 2015 numbers

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

IT HAS BEEN full of twists, real and imagined. Caution had filled the April air as the Siddaramaiah regime dusted off Karnataka's 2015 caste survey report. Tense cabinet meets ensued, amid a feared backlash from the Lingayat-Vokkaliga caste duopoly. Meanwhile, a googly came from the Centre: on April 30, after years of holding out, it relented on including a national caste count in the 2026 census. The Congress claimed credit for forcing the U-turn, but soon made one of its own. Karnataka effectively junked the 2015 report. Instead, between September 22 and October 7, some 165,000 enumerators will fan out with handheld devices for a de novo sorting of the state's 70-odd million.



Takeaways

- **Karnataka will conduct a fresh caste survey this September-October**
- **The 2024 report, based on the 2015 survey from Sidda's 1st term, is junked**
- **Lingayats, Vokkaligas, the two dominant caste groups, had questioned the validity of 2015 data**

WHY ALL OVER AGAIN?

What ordained a fresh caste survey? The 2015 one, a pet Siddaramaiah project, didn't yield a report till he demitted office. It fell upon him, when he was back as CM in 2023, to retrieve it from the freezer and order an analysis of its data.

The ensuing 2024 report ran smack into the minefield everyone knew lay out there, counting Lingayats and Vokkaligas at 11.09 per cent and 10.31 per cent of the population, respectively, far slimmer than the long-set-in-stone 17/12 per cent, an anticipated diminution that had all along raised cries of the 2015 survey being 'unscientific'. "Their interest was to maintain status quo," says a legal expert familiar with the heated cabinet debates.

"But a statutory bar prevented progress," he explains. The report called for hiking backward quotas from 32 per cent to 51 per cent. The snag? Not just a breach of the Supreme Court's 50 per cent cap. The 2015 data was 'outdated'. Several SC verdicts insist on 'contemporaneous' data for any revising of backward classes, which the report had done in two categories. "This is the primary basis on which it was put on hold," says the expert.

Caste groups welcome the new survey, if guardedly. The Opposition calls it profligacy. Others look forward to richer data, upgrading from an X-ray to an MRI of Karnataka's society, economy and polity. ■